

Chapter 14

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The diversity within the “Hispanic” population in the U.S.
- A discussion of bilingualism, code switching, and Spanish accents
- The connection between race, ethnicity, and language in regards to the Latino/a population in the U.S.
- The performance of race
- The use of language to indicate social solidarity
- A variety of discriminatory practices against Latino/as based on language
- A description of the discrimination against Cirila Baltazar Cruz, a Chatino woman living in the United States
- Racism against Latino/as in the workplace
- Discrimination against Latino/a children in the educational system
- The connection between linguistic discrimination and immigration in the Southwest
- A discussion of HR 2083, an Arizona bill that prohibits schools from offering courses that advocate ethnic solidarity, promote overthrow of the U.S. government, or cater to specific ethnic groups
- Educational policies that discriminate against teachers who speak English with an accent
- The French-Only language policy in Quebec

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. Listen to Andre Codrescu's essay “Arizona Education Loses the Accent of America” (May 10, 2010) on National Public Radio. Does his perspective change your thoughts about anything in this chapter? How is it relevant to the chapter – and book – in a broader sense? Radio link at <http://www.npr.org/templates/story/story.php?storyId=126480169>

Sample answer: Codrescu’s essay does change my perspective on the Arizona laws that allow the police to ask people for proof of citizenship and the laws that require teachers to speak English without an L2 accent. The comparison he draws between communist Rumania in the 1960s and present-day Arizona is frightening, and helps drive home just what that law entails for people’s everyday lives. Mentioning that Professor Albert Einstein taught with an accent very effectively highlights the point that a person’s accent does not indicate that person’s intelligence or ability to teach well.

This essay is relevant to the chapter and the book as a whole in a broader sense because Codrescu makes the points that everybody has an accent, accents are not related to intelligence or competence, and discriminating based on accents is oppressive.

2. Davila (Davila et al. 1993) undertook a preliminary, explorative statistical analysis of earnings by three groups of workers in the U.S.: Mexican-Americans, German Americans and Italian Americans who speak their heritage language at home (and thus, Davila et al postulated, spoke with an accent). In fact, the analysis indicated that those of Mexican ancestry earned significantly less than the other two groups. They suggest that Mexicans who have a closer affinity to their heritage culture pay a penalty for that preference, but they also list a number of other possible reasons for the discrepancy in earnings. Discuss what you think those reasons may be. Think in terms of immigration history and trends, geographic distribution, and legal considerations in addition to ethnicity and language.

Sample answer: I think that a major reason for this discrepancy would be racism plus widely-held American attitudes towards German, Italian, and Mexican accents. Many people would favor the European accents over an accent that indicates the speaker is from Mexico. Other reasons might be connected to America's increased acceptance of immigrants from Europe (since the original American colonies were founded by Europeans) and widespread fear of illegal immigration in border states (where the stereotypical illegal immigrant is from Mexico).

3. Consider the history of discriminatory practices taken against Native Americans as described briefly in Chapter 7, and compare that information (and any other research you might do on this topic) to Padgett's TIME Magazine article about the Cruz case in Mississippi. What similarities do you see? How relevant are they to language focused discrimination?

Sample answer: The primary similarity I see between the Cruz case in Mississippi and the discriminatory practices taken against Native Americans in the history of the United States is the decision to take Native American children away from their non-English speaking parents. In Cruz's case, she did not speak the languages of either group of colonizers (English and Spanish), so her baby daughter was taken away "for the good of the child." Cruz's situation illustrates a modern-day case of the discriminatory practices that resulted in forcing Native American children into English-Only boarding schools "for their own good."

4. Make a list of terms for people of Latino origin. (If you are yourself Latino/a, you can still undertake this exercise – but you should concentrate on non-Spanish speakers when collecting data. If you are not comfortable with this, you could take a different approach, and make a similar list of Spanish language terms for non Spanish speakers in the U.S.) Ask acquaintances, friends, family for help. In class, find a way to divide all the terms collected into groups. Are some terms purely derogatory and racist? Are there neutral terms which seem to be fairly safe; that is, they won't offend the majority of Latinos? How many of the terms do you use yourself, and which ones do you avoid? Can you reconstruct what goes through your mind if/when you use a term like wetback? This is not meant to be an exercise in blame; the purpose is to pinpoint the way you have learned to think about a particular ethnic group.

Sample answer: The terms I gathered for people of Latino origin were: *Latino/a*, *Chicano*, *Mexican*, *Hispanic*, *wetback*, and *beaner*. Of these terms, I only use the first three (although I used to use the word *Hispanic* as well before I realized the controversy around the term). I also

only refer to someone as *Mexican* or *Mexican American* if I know the person is of Mexican ancestry, unlike a lot of people in my area who use the term *Mexican* is an umbrella term to refer to anybody of Latino origin. I think the term *Latino/a* would be the most neutral term, as would *Chicano* and *Mexican* or *Mexican American* (at least when used accurately). I think the terms *wetback* and *beaner* are offensive, which is why I never use them.

5. Consider the Arizona School Board's intention to send out inspectors to decide whether a teacher speaks English fluently enough to work with Spanish-speaking children who are learning English. Can you imagine putting together a program (training the investigators, etc) that would reach judicious, consistent evaluations? What would that look like?

Sample answer: I don't know that this can be done fairly (and there are issues with language assessment in general anyway), but if I had to put together such a program, I guess I would observe the teacher in class with his or her students and (somehow) determine how many times the communication breaks down irreparably. If there were irreparable communication breakdowns, then I guess I would have to (somehow) determine the importance of the information that the student did not receive. I would also have to (somehow) compare the misunderstandings to the number of communication break downs that happen in classrooms with native English speaking teachers and then (somehow) weigh the importance of the misunderstandings with the effectiveness of the teacher as a whole. This sounds like a pretty impossible process ...

6. How is the language situation in Quebec relevant to the conflicts in the U.S. Southwest? Do you feel the Francophone laws in Quebec were well founded? Reasonable? Understandable? What do you think might happen if/when the Spanish speaking population of Arizona reaches a strong majority?

Sample answer: I think the Francophones in Quebec were reacting to hundreds of years of discrimination against their French-dominant ancestors. It is understandable to want to bring one's language into the public sphere, but the Francophones kept the same level of discrimination going, they just reversed it to be aimed at Anglophones instead. I think it's possible that a Spanish-speaking majority could enact Spanish-Only programs in Arizona, but I don't know that it's likely to happen. I also think that much of the rest of the country would react very strongly against Spanish-Only policies, which might complicate such a situation.

7. Explore the Pew Hispanic Center website by following the link to "Survey Reports." Identify an issue that is (a) language related and (b) could be addressed, at least in part, by "making the invisible visible" to Anglos.

Sample answer: According to a survey taken between August 17 and September 19, 2010 (<http://pewhispanic.org/questions/?qid=1772973&pid=54&ccid=54#top>), language skills was the number two reported reason why Latinos think people of Latino origin face discrimination in the U.S. The number one reason was immigration status and the number three reason was skin color.

By making the system of institutionalized linguistic discrimination more visible to Anglos, people may realize that discrimination based on accent is not acceptable.

8. Consider the Census maps from the 2007 American Community Survey in this chapter. Note that those areas of the country which are most heavily bilingual Spanish/English are not necessarily the areas where English language facility is lowest. Why might that be, for example, in New Mexico?

Sample answer: In places like New Mexico, there may be very stable, long-term Spanish-English bilingual communities in which many people speak both English and Spanish natively or fluently. A speaker's fluency in Spanish doesn't give any indication of his or her fluency in English. Language is not a zero-sum game.

9. *"Discomfort is not oppression. It is a sign of privilege when white students believe they should be able to understand everything going on around them or never have their racial embodiment questioned publicly."* Discuss.

Sample answer: I agree that it is a sign of privilege when monolingual English speakers expect to always be able to understand conversations around them. For many white speakers (at least those who do not speak a stigmatized variety of English natively), they take it for granted that the legitimacy of the language and language variety that they speak, along with their racial embodiment, will never be questioned.

10. Pursue the issue of the Mexican-American Ethnic Studies Program in the Tucson school district. A few places to start:

- Strauss, Valerie. May 25, 2010 "Why Arizona targeted ethnic studies." *The Washington Post*. <http://xrl.in/72an>
- Arizona, in the Classroom [Editorial]. 2011. *The New York Times*. January 17: A22. <http://xrl.in/72ks>
- Tucson United School District Mexican American Studies Department Presentation to the TUSD Governing Board January 12, 2010 Director: Sean Arce, M.Ed. <http://xrl.in/72ar>
- The full text of an e-mail exchange between Dr. Rodolfo Acuña and KGUN9 News director Forrest Carr. For ease of reading, Carr's questions are highlighted in yellow. The non-highlighted portions are Dr. Acuña's responses. <http://xrl.in/72au>

KGUN9 ABC Tucson articles

- June 3, 2010. "Author slams Arizona education boss over ethnic studies ban." <http://xrl.in/72ao>

- October 19, 2010 "Does TUSD's ethnic studies program violate Arizona's new law?" <http://xrl.in/72ap>
- May 24, 2010 "What ethnic studies students are learning: an inside look." <http://xrl.in/72av>

Sample answer: Answers will vary.

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the samples of all the accents mentioned in this chapter and consider the following quote from chapter 14 (p. 261):

Just as Disney never thought to give the character of a carpenter (or a fire fighter, or a street sweeper) a French accent, filmmakers find it difficult to imagine Latinos/as as accountants, copy shop owners, engineers or veterinarians.

In which kinds of roles do you think these accents are most often used? Why? What does this reveal about standard language ideology?

Sample answer: As the book says, I think most Latino/a characters that speak Chicano English, Puerto Rican English, Cuban English, or English with an L2 Spanish accent are most usually portrayed as urban drug dealers, gang members or rural migrant workers. This ignores the wide range of lifestyles and professions of real-life Latino/as. As described in Chapter 7, French accents are often restricted to characters with interests in sex and food, which not only ignores the wide range of French people who have additional interests, but also ignores the wide range of people of non-French origin who have such interests. I don't know of any examples of the language variety spoken by locals on Martha's Vineyard being used in a movie, but I would imagine if it were, it would be used by a restricted subset of the actual population that uses it. I would expect that fisherman or people with other traditional occupations would be using it rather than, say a real estate agent or a lawyer.

I think these stereotypical movie roles are a result of stereotypes about the people who speak these language varieties and the power of standard language ideology, which would lead people to expect certain language varieties to correspond with certain social roles. For example, despite the fact that there are plenty of urban criminals who speak something close to *SAE and plenty of white collar professionals who speak Chicano English, standard language ideology attempts to maintain traditional linguistic stereotypes.

2. Listen to the samples from speakers with Chicano, Puerto Rican, and Cuban backgrounds. What variation do you hear between these speakers?

Sample answer: I hear considerable variation between these speakers. First of all, I hear variation in the speakers' use of distinctive features of Chicano, Puerto Rican, and Cuban

English and the number of features that would indicate a Spanish L1 (for the nonnative speakers) – some speakers have more features than others. In addition, regional variation is also noticeable; for example, New York 3 has features of New York English in his speech.

3. Listen to the samples of the language variety spoken on Martha's Vineyard and revisit the information about Labov's famous study of the connection between language and identity (p. 266; also explained on the website where the sound files can be found). Are there any linguistic variables that are linked to a local identity in your area?

Sample answer: Yes, there are. One linguistic variable that stands out (because it is a well-known and conscious marker of local identity) is the use of the word *hella* to indicate an allegiance to a northern California identity. To my knowledge, the word *hella* is in use from the San Francisco Bay area on up but not in the southern regions of the state (in fact, I have heard people in southern California scorn the word as a marker of northern identity). Like the pronunciations of diphthongs on Martha's Vineyard, the word *hella* indicates an affiliation with a geographic place.

Video

Bill Santiago–“Spanglish”
Comedy Central Stand-Up

<http://comedians.jokes.com/bill-santiago/videos/bill-santiago---spanglish/>

1. Evaluate the various facets of Bill Santiago's language ideology (based on what he says in this routine).

Sample answer: Bill Santiago's language ideology appears to be very interesting based on what he says in his routine. First of all, his comments about an audience member who was thankful not to know Spanish reveals that he places a high value on Spanish, and his use of some features of Puerto Rican English and Spanish indicate that he values these language varieties as integral to his identity. However, he does not seem to value code switching in the same way that he values “pure” Spanish or “pure” English. His comment that “Spanglish” is twice the vocabulary and half the grammar reveals that he considers code switching to be a deficient form of communicating. This is where much of the humor in this clip comes from—the audience is laughing at “the ridiculousness” of code switching.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Ask your students what their initial reactions are to code switching. Have they ever thought code switching indicated a lack of proficiency in either (or both) language(s)? Has their opinions of code switching changed after reading this chapter? Do any of the students participate in code switching between any two (or more) languages? If so, what do they think about code switching?
2. Have your students research the grammatical and social rules that govern code switching and ask them to write a research paper that describes what they found.

3. If you live in an area where Spanish (or another language) is frequently used, ask the students to listen and watch for code switching in conversation, on television or radio, and in printed communication. Have them take notes during their observation period to record who code switched and in what context. Ask the students to look for patterns in their results and bring their findings in to share with the class. Discuss code switching situation in your area.
4. Have your students research the differences between Chicano English, Puerto Rican English, and Cuban English, or research the diversity within one of those language varieties and ask them to write a research paper that describes what they found.
5. Discuss how language varieties such as Chicano English are not “broken” English and do not contain English learner “errors” but are rule-governed dialects of English and can be spoken by monolingual speakers of English. Ask the students if they think they can tell whether or not a speaker of Chicano English is bilingual in English and Spanish or monolingual in English. If so, what features indicate monolingualism or bilingualism? After this discussion, take the Chicano English quiz found on the *Do You Speak American?* website (<http://www.pbs.org/speak/seatosea/americanvarieties/chicano/quiz/#>) and then revisit the topic.
6. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.